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Blogging

I would write a blog explaining the rules and basics of basketball for casual fans or anyone new to the topic. My posts would cover all the rules of basketball, why someone gets a violation or a foul called on them, and basic plays and actions you can run on defense or offense.

My audience for this would be people new to watching or playing the sport and trying to pick up the basic actions. This would typically be for people who are older and didn't play or learn any basketball at a younger age but want to learn later in life.

Some blogs that would compete with my blog are Basketball Immersion and Breakthrough Basketball Basics. Immersion is a blog that will go into skill acquisition and offensive concepts, and then Breakthrough goes over fouls and or violations and standard positions. What will set us apart from these other two blogs is the fact that we would be them both in one; one is more concept-based based and the other is more rules based and my blog would be the both of those combined.

Several key features included that I would include in my blog would be using real clips from televised games and breaking down why the call was made, and then a difficulty meter for readers so it's labeled for people who are new and can find the simplest concepts and people who know more can read the more complex concepts.

So, for my content calendar, we would start with the very basics and the easiest rules. For the first posts of the first month, we would go over the easiest rules of basketball, like 5 players on the court and all the other very easy concepts, with some of the harder stuff included at the end, but the main focus being the simplest of things. So then, the next topic we will dive into some more of the violations and rules that get harder to understand, and with those ones especially, we will include videos of the rule or violation being broken to show an example of what is happening. Then, some ideas for the next month: after a lot of the rules have been covered, we would start covering basic offensive concepts with just 2-player actions and then get all the way into full-blown plays. The last potential topic would be defensive concepts and types of defenses, what the goal of said defense would be and what would beat that defense.

AI helped me with this layout by giving me key features that would help set my blog apart from others. https://claude.ai/share/17b99e37-6b08-415c-abf4-a6ca3145601d

What Is the defense actually trying to do? A guide for new players and fans

There are two basic types of defenses you will see played in basketball, and that's man-to-man and zone. You can build off of those and run many different types and do some very complex concepts, but it all boils down to one or the other, and I will explain how they both work and some of the different ways they can be played.

Basics of man-to-man defense

Man-to-man defense is by far the most common and simplest defense in all of basketball. This defense involves each player on defense on the court having the responsibility of guarding one of the five offensive players. You will have your person you are guarding, and that specific person is your main responsibility. When your player has the ball, you will be keeping yourself between the ball and the hoop to close easy driving lanes for the offensive player. When the ball is away from you, you need to position yourself so that you can see the ball and your player moving depending on where the ball is. If the ball is one pass away from you, you need to be up in what is often called the deny position, which is where you are up in the passing lane to deny your player from receiving a pass while maintaining a position to help your teammate if they get blown by and their offensive player is going past them. If you are more than one pass away, you drop back into a help-side position. In the help-side position, you will be really focused on being in a place to help your teammates and defend the paint and drives while being in a place where, if they throw a pass to your player, you can recover and close out on your player. The last important thing you need to know about man defense is switching, which is when you exchange your player matchup with a teammate when you or they are screened, or your players are switching around. The key concept is that switching is just communication so you both are on the same page.

Basics and common types of zone defenses

Unlike man defense, where you have a specific player, in a zone defense your responsibility is a specific area on the court or a "zone." The three most common zone defenses are the 2-3 zone, a 1-3-1 zone, and a 1-2-2/3-2 zone, where the numbers represent a player and the order is the position they are in on the floor.

So, in a 2-3 zone, you will have two players positioned on the top of the defense with three across the bottom. The responsibility of the top two guards is to split the top part, pressure the ball and cover the perimeter. The outside two on the bottom will cover the wing and corners, and then your biggest person will anchor in the lane and protect the paint. This defense is great for protecting the paint and rebounding.

In a 1-3-1 zone, you will have one player who will be up front close to half court, then three across right around the free-throw line and one in the paint. You want someone with long arms and quick to play your top position because they are the key to creating a lot of turnovers in this defense. You want to put your big either in the middle of the three-across or the bottom of the whole thing, then just fill in the rest. Your goal is to get the ball to the corner, then trap the corner to cause turnovers.

Then, last is the 1-2-2/3-2 zone; these two defenses are very similar, with the build being similar, but when you run a 1-2-2, your two elbow players cover the wings and then your two block guys will cover the paint and the corners but your top guy in a 1-2-2 will do what is called a "yo-yo" where they will drop with the ball if it goes to the corner they will be on the strong side block but with a 3-2 your middle of the top three won't drop down at all. This defense is good for defending 3-pointers and turning a turnover into a fast-break opportunity.

How to beat these defenses

The key way to beat a man defense is by setting screens and moving. A great way is to isolate one defender by running a pick-and-roll where someone sets a screen for the ball handler and then rolls toward the basket. If run well, this will isolate the player defending the screener into picking who to guard, leading to someone being open.

How you beat these zones all banks on getting the ball to a certain spot on the floor and moving the ball quickly. The 2-3: You will want to get the ball to the high post, and then quick shots in the corner are the biggest weaknesses for them. 1-3-1: Your weakness is the skip pass. If they get a good skip pass and catch you out of position, you are done for, and then the corner 3-pointer is open if you don't move quickly on the trap. The 1-2-2/3-2: the lack of paint protection and rebounding is the weakness of this type of zone defense.

The bottom line

Man-to-man and zone defenses both aim to take away easy shots, but they go about it differently. Man-to-man is individual-focused compared to zone, where you protect space.

Next time you are watching a game, try to figure out the type of defense a team is running. Once you pick out the defense, you will see what teams will try to do to beat it and what actually works.